resources. While doing so in one's head was a formidable challenge, it was easy for a learned scribe to write them down on a clay tablet.[13]

Like stories and like all other information technologies in history, written documents didn't necessarily represent reality accurately. The Ur tablet, for example, contained a mistake. The document says that 896 animals were received during that month, but when modern scholars added up all the individual entries they reached a total of 898. The scribe who wrote the document apparently made a mistake when he calculated the overall tally, and the tablet preserved this mistake for posterity.

But whether true or false, written documents created new realities. By recording lists of properties, taxes and payments, they made it far easier to create administrative systems, kingdoms, religious organisations and trade networks. More specifically, documents changed the method used for creating intersubjective realities. In oral cultures, intersubjective realities were created by telling a story that many people repeated with their mouths and remembered in their brains. Brain capacity consequently placed a limit on the kinds of intersubjective realities that humans created. Humans couldn't forge an intersubjective reality that their brains couldn't remember.

This limit could be transcended, however, by writing documents. The documents didn't represent an objective empirical reality; the reality was the documents themselves. As we shall see in later chapters, written documents thereby provided precedents and models that would eventually be used by computers. The ability of computers to create intersubjective realities is an extension of the power of clay tablets and pieces of paper.

As a key example, consider ownership. In oral communities that lacked written documents, ownership was an intersubjective reality created through the words and behaviours of the community members. To own a field meant that your neighbours agreed that this field was yours, and they behaved accordingly. They didn't build a hut on that field, graze their livestock there or pick fruits there without first asking your permission. Ownership was created and maintained by people continuously saying or signalling things to one another. This made ownership the affair of a local community and placed a limit on the ability of a distant central authority to control all landownership. No king, minister or priest could remember who owned each field in hundreds of distant villages. This also placed a limit on the ability of individuals to claim and exercise absolute property rights, and instead favoured various forms of communal property rights. For example,